

Manabozho and the Muskrat

Ojibwe Story

This is a story about the muskrat, a very important animal to the Ojibwe. Once, in the time of Manabozho, the muskrat helped the Ojibwe people survive a great flood.

Many, many years ago, there was a terrible flood. The waters rose higher and higher and finally Manabozho was forced to look for shelter on higher ground. He remembered a high hill he knew, and took refuge there.

Growing on top of this hill was a tall tree and when Manabozho realized that the waters were continuing to rise, he climbed to the top of that tree. Eventually, the waters reached the spot where he sat.

Now, we must remember that Manabozho was a special being and could talk to all manner of living beings. When the water reached him, Manabozho simply asked the tree to stretch and grow taller. The tree did. Manabozho asked the tree to do this four times and each time the tree grew taller. However, the water continued to rise and each time reached the spot where Manabozho sat.

Right about this time, Manabozho finally began to get worried. He called to all the animal brothers and said, "We must work together. If we don't do something now, there will be no more earth!!"

The animals gathered together, swimming around the tree where Manabozho sat. One by one, Manabozho told each one, the duck, the beaver, and all of the other animals, to dive into the water and see how deep it was. And each took his turn, but he never returned. You see, they drowned.

Eventually, a muskrat came swimming along. Manabozho stopped him and asked, "Will you do me a favor?"

"Certainly," replied the muskrat. "What is it?"

"Will you go down to the bottom and get me some earth?" asked Manabozho.

The muskrat went down and was gone a long time. Finally, his body floated up to the surface. Manabozho, using a branch, pulled him out of the water.

The muskrat looked dead, but Manabozho blew on him until he came to life. When he opened the muskrat's paw, he found a few grains of sand. When Manabozho threw these on the water, earth appeared. Manabozho kept working and the earth became bigger and bigger.

When he felt that the earth might be big enough, Manabozho told a young fox to run around to see how big it was. The fox was gone a very long time and when he finally returned, he was an old fox.

Just to make sure that there had not been a mistake, Manabozho told a young wolf to run around the world and when that wolf returned, he was an old wolf.

It was then that Manabozho knew for certain that the earth was large enough.

Source Material Cited:

“Manabozho and the Muskrat.” Edited by Paul C Barry, *Canku OTA - July 15, 2000 - Muskrats*,

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